

English Prep — Ernest

Your plan before the entrance test

Good news first: on the practice test you scored **82%**, and your prepositions, word order, plurals and basic tenses were **all 100%**. You don't need to study those. 🙌

This plan just tightens **three things** that slipped. About **30 minutes a day**. That's it.

🔑 **Two rules that matter most**

1. **Write your answers — don't just pick a/b/c.** You're already good at spotting the right answer. The test wants you to *produce* it, so practise by writing full sentences.
2. **On the real exam, check your work twice at the end:** one read looking *only* at **a / the**, one read looking *only* at **verb tenses**. This alone catches most mistakes.

The plan

If your test is sooner than 4 days, just do Day 1 and Day 2 — they matter most.

Day	Focus	What to do
Day 1	Conditionals (the "would have" fix)	Read Lesson 1 + do the practice. Then write 6–8 sentences: " <i>If you could change one thing about your new school, what would it be?</i> " Reread it: would + verb for now, and no will/would in the "if" part.
Day 2	Articles (a / the / nothing)	Read Lesson 2 + do the practice. Then write 6–8 sentences <i>describing your room</i> (makes you use lots of <i>a</i> and <i>the</i>). Reread: no " <i>a</i> " before <i>advice / information / homework</i> , and " <i>the</i> " for specific things.
Day 3	Present perfect (for / since)	Read Lesson 3 + do the practice. Then write 6–8 sentences: " <i>Three things you have done this year, and how long you have had your favourite thing.</i> "
Day 4 test eve	Light review	Redo the first practice test (all 22 questions) and try to beat 82%. Skim the three lesson summaries once more. No new studying tonight — sleep well. 😴

- ✅ **On test day**
- Read each question carefully — don't rush.
 - Answer everything (a guess beats a blank).
 - Save the **last 3–4 minutes** for your two checks: **a/the**, then **verb tenses**.

You've got a solid base already. This is just polishing. You've got this. 🚀

Lesson 1 — Conditionals: the "would have" trap

Your biggest fixable thing. An examiner spots this instantly.

What happened on the test:

"If I had more time, I would **have learnt** to code."

"If I were rich, I would **have bought** a new computer."

Your *if*-part was perfect both times. The problem was only the second half — you added **have**.

The rule — it's about TIME

Situation	If-part	Result-part	Example
Imaginary now / future (2nd conditional)	past simple	would + verb	If I had time, I would learn to code.
Imaginary past — didn't happen (3rd conditional)	had + V3	would have + V3	If I had had time last year, I would have learned to code.

"would have + V3" is only for the past — things that are over and can't change. "If I were rich" is about *now*, so it's just **"I would buy"**, not "would have bought."

And never put **will** or **would** in the *if*-part: "If I **finish** my homework..." (not **will finish**).

Russian check: Russian uses one form — *бы* + *past* — for both. English splits it by time, so ask yourself: *am I imagining now, or regretting the past?*

Practice — write the whole sentence

1. If I were you, I would have chosen the guitar. (you mean: now / generally)
2. If it will rain tomorrow, we will stay home.
3. Если бы у меня был брат, я бы играл с ним в футбол. (→ English)
4. If she had studied harder last year, she would pass the exam.
5. If I lived in Kazakhstan, I would have skied every winter. (you mean: now / generally)
6. Если бы я знал ответ, я бы тебе сказал. (→ English, about now)

Lesson 2 — Articles: the "a" to drop, the "the" to keep

Your longest-standing weak spot — worth the most careful attention.

What happened:

"teacher gave me **a** good advice" — *advice* can't take *a*

In your writing: "prefer **climate**", "continuing **IGCSE system**" — both needed **the**

A) Uncountable nouns take NO "a" and NO plural -s

Ideas or substances you can't count one-by-one:

advice, information, news, money, furniture, homework, progress, weather, research, knowledge

- **a good advice** → **good advice** / some good advice
- **informations** → **information**
- **a good progress** → **good progress**

B) Use "the" when the thing is specific

Already known, or the only one here:

- "the climate" — you mean *the climate of Kazakhstan*, a specific one → **the**
- "the IGCSE system" — the particular system you're joining → **the**
- "the best student", "the exam we're taking" — specific → **the**

Russian check: Russian has no articles, so two opposite errors leak in — you *add* "a" where English uses nothing (uncountables), and you *drop* "the" where English needs it (specific things). When you write, pause on every noun: *is it countable? is it a specific one?*

Practice — write the whole sentence

1. My teacher gave us an important information about the exam.
2. I need to buy a new furniture for my room.
3. Climate in Kazakhstan is colder than in Bahrain. (specific climate)
4. She made a good progress in maths this term.
5. Учитель объяснил домашнее задание. (→ English; "the teacher", specific homework)
6. I want to study computer science at a new school I'm joining. (specific school)
7. He gave me a very useful advices.
8. News about the move was a surprise. (specific news you just heard)

Lesson 3 — Present perfect: "for / since" and "have you ever"

What happened:

"I know him **since three years old**." — two problems: wrong tense + since/for mix-up

The rule — have / has + V3 (the third verb form)

Use it for:

- **Experience**, no time said: *Have you ever been to Almaty? I have played this game before.*
- **Something that started in the past and is still true now** — with **for** or **since**:
 - **for** + how long: *for three years, for a week, for ten minutes*
 - **since** + when it started: *since 2021, since Monday, since I was ten*

So: **I know him since three years old** → **I have known him for three years** (a length of time), or **since we were ten** (a starting point).

Russian check: Russian says this in the *present* — *Я знаю его три года* ("I know him three years"). English needs **have known** + **for**. This is the #1 tense trap for Russian speakers — whenever you see "for X years up to now", reach for *have/has* + V3.

Practice — write the whole sentence

1. I live in Bahrain since 2015.
2. We know each other for a long time.
3. Ты когда-нибудь пробовал играть на гитаре? (→ English)
4. She is my best friend since primary school.
5. I have this bike for two years and it still works.
6. Я знаю его с детства. (→ English)

Answer keys

Try every sentence yourself first — then check here.

Lesson 1 — Conditionals

1. If I were you, I **would choose** the guitar. (now → no "have")
2. If it **rains** tomorrow, we will stay home. (no "will" in the if-part)
3. If I **had** a brother, I **would play** football with him.
4. If she had studied harder last year, she **would have passed** the exam. (past → "have" is correct here)
5. If I lived in Kazakhstan, I **would ski** every winter. (now → no "have")
6. If I **knew** the answer, I **would tell** you.

Lesson 2 — Articles

1. ...gave us **important information** about the exam. (no "an")
2. I need to buy **new furniture** for my room. (no "a")
3. **The climate** in Kazakhstan is colder... (specific)
4. She **made good progress** in maths... (no "a")
5. **The teacher explained the homework.** ("homework" is uncountable — no "a"/no -s)
6. ...at **the new school** I'm joining. (specific → "the")
7. He gave me **very useful advice.** (no "a", no -s)
8. **The news** about the move **was** a surprise. ("news" is uncountable — singular verb)

Lesson 3 — Present perfect

1. I **have lived** in Bahrain since 2015.
2. We **have known** each other for a long time.
3. **Have you ever tried** playing the guitar?
4. She **has been** my best friend since primary school.
5. I **have had** this bike for two years and it still works.
6. I **have known** him since childhood. (or: since I was a child)

Made for Ernest · 30 minutes a day · You only need these three things. Good luck! 